

dysfunctional before discarding it. There are more ways than you know of recovering your data.

► **Don't store your documents on the same drive as your OS**

This may sound like basic advice, but is a big no-no. Most software products install or save files in the My Documents folder of your primary drive (usually c:\), but this is the worst place to have them saved. Why? Sometimes, there are software failures or viruses, which would require you to reinstall the OS and thus format the entire drive. This would mean losing all the data on your drive, and is exactly why you should always have separate drives for your data and your operating system. You can just partition the drive using partition software and save your data in the new partition – beware though that doing this may violate the warranty conditions on your hard disk. Alternatively, you can just get an additional internal or external drive to store your data separately; which also helps you take the next measure.

► **Keep backing up!**

The best practice for effective backing up: regular backups. We know we've made this clear, but backing up your machine regularly can protect you from the unexpected. Files you'd want to back up from time to time might include data such as your recent documents, application data and, most importantly, system backups. Sure, you can always reinstall Windows (or any other OS) and your apps in case of failure, but switching to a recently created system backup (a.k.a a disaster recovery backup) will ensure that the transition is much smoother. You could just program your OS to automatically back up for you in scheduled time intervals.

► **Keep verifying your backup data**

You want to ensure that the backups you're taking are indeed being stored in a retrievable manner. Imagine spending all that time to back up data only to find out that it wasn't being done as you intended, or – to your absolute horror – that the files weren't really being stored at all! It might be time consuming, but verifying that your backed up data is indeed present and in its latest version is essential to ensure reliable backups.

There you go. We've covered the absolute basic things to do to ensure that your data is safe. These are generic measures that everyone must take. We'll be focusing on the more specific backup solutions available to you over the next few chapters. 